

# POSC 3710: European Politics

9/2/2026: EUROPE AFTER THE SECOND WORLD WAR

DR. WILL HORNE

CLEMSON UNIVERSITY



# Today: Germany Is Rearming

- Germany's 2026 defence budget is €108bn — 2.5% of GDP
- More than double the €48bn it spent in 2021
- The plan from here: €162bn and 3.5% of GDP by 2029
- Target of 260,000 active troops; registration of 18-year-old men resumed in January
- Merz: Germany will build “the strongest conventional army in Europe”
  - Germany certainly not alone in re-arming



# And the Americans Are Leaving

- 5,000 US troops ordered out of Germany, leaving about 30,000
  - Trump: “we’re cutting a lot further than 5,000”
- EU defence spending projected at €454bn in 2026
- Europe is being asked to defend itself for the first time since 1949
  - Is the alliance with America breaking, or is this just Europe finally doing it’s part?

# Are we renegotiating the post-war settlement?

## GERMAN POWER

**1951**

Coal and steel pooled under a High Authority, so Germany cannot rearm alone

**2026**

€108bn defence budget, and its neighbours are asking it to lead

## AMERICAN PRESENCE

**1949**

NATO commits the United States to European defence

**2026**

Terms of security guarantee are more unclear than ever, *and* troops are leaving

## EUROPEAN UNITY

**1957**

Six members, common market, governed by a fairly popular centrist coalition

**2026**

Enlargement reopened, and the center-left and center-right are in disarray



# Where We Left Off

- Monday: how the Weimar Republic was dismantled from the inside
  - Why other countries were more resilient
- **Spoiler Alert:** War followed, by 1945 most of Europe had been occupied by fascists, and tens of millions were dead
- Today: how Western Europe was rebuilt after 1945



# Opening Discussion

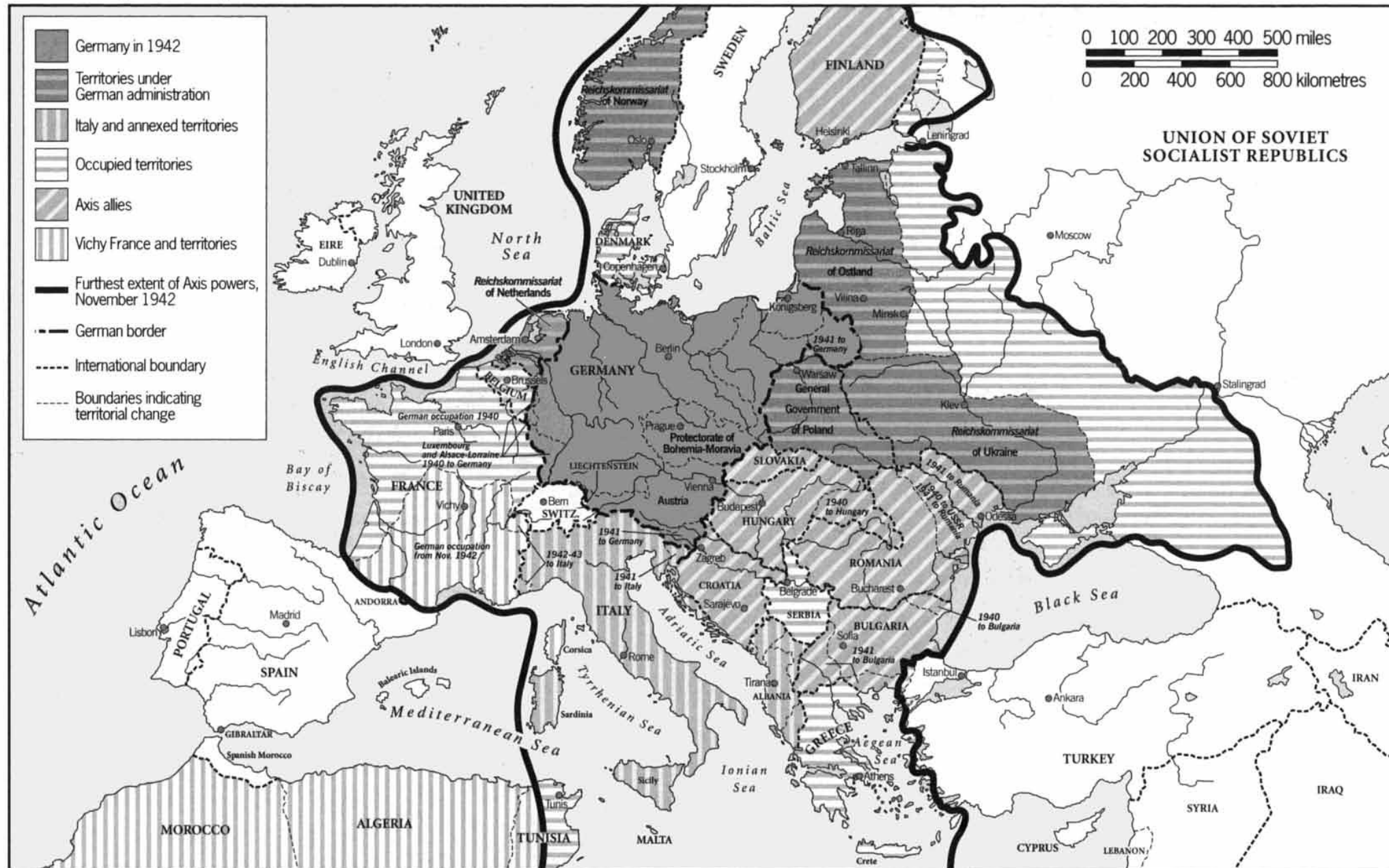
- You are governing a European country in 1945.
  - What do you do about Germany?
  - Who pays for reconstruction, and what will they want in return?
  - What would make you give up part of your own sovereignty?



# Europe at the End of the War

- Judt: Exhausted, hopeless, and with reason
- For occupied Europe the war was a civilian experience
  - Repression and occupation, not battle
- Hunger, destruction, and refugees moving west
- In the British zone of Germany, official rations fell to about 1,000 calories a day in 1946

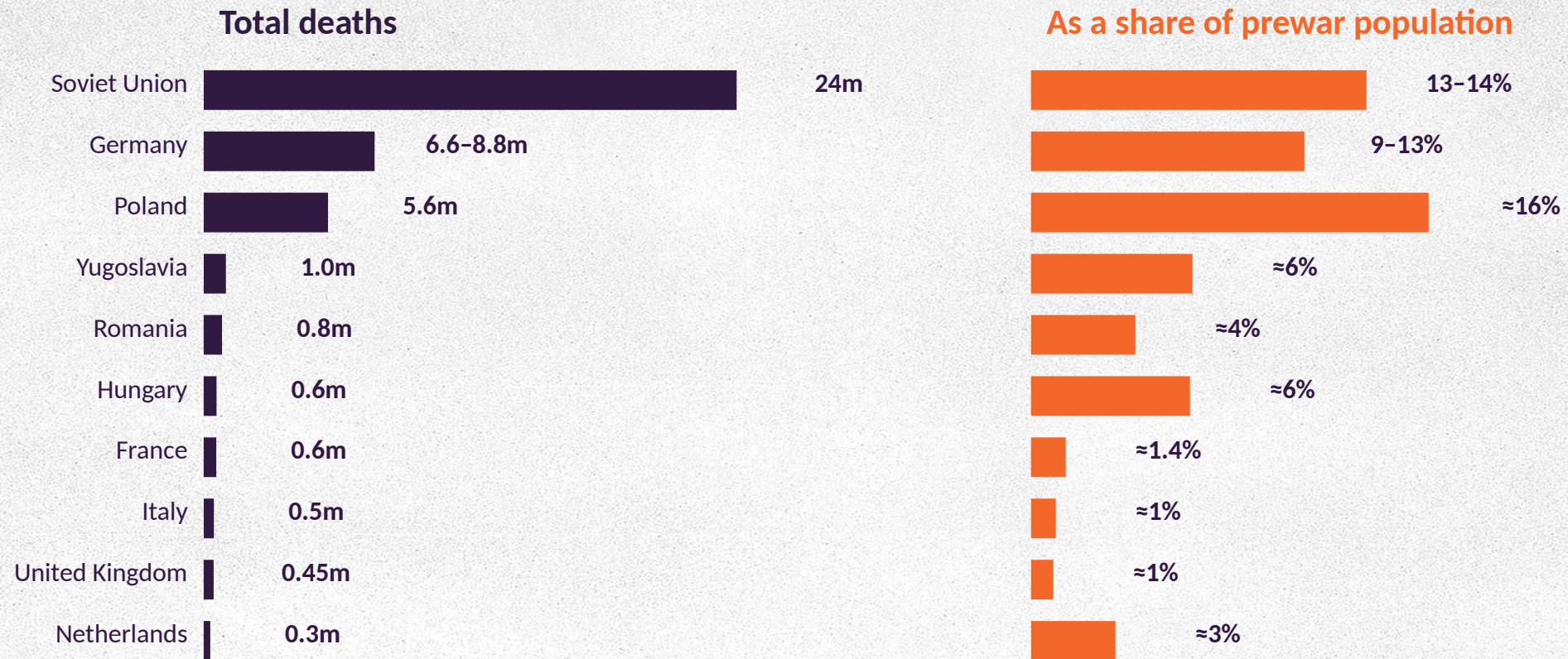
# Axis-Occupied Europe: November 1942





# The human cost

Worldwide: roughly 15 million battle deaths and 45 million civilian deaths



Deaths: National WWII Museum estimates.



# The Holocaust

## ESTIMATED VICTIMS — US HOLOCAUST MEMORIAL MUSEUM

|                                           |                              |
|-------------------------------------------|------------------------------|
| Jews                                      | 6,000,000                    |
| Soviet civilians*                         | around 7,000,000             |
| Soviet prisoners of war                   | around 3,000,000             |
| Non-Jewish Polish civilians               | around 1,800,000             |
| Serb civilians                            | 312,000                      |
| People with disabilities, in institutions | up to 250,000                |
| Roma                                      | up to 250,000                |
| Repeat offenders and so-called asocials   | at least 70,000              |
| LGBTQ+                                    | hundreds, possibly thousands |
| Jehovah's Witnesses                       | around 1,900                 |

*\*Includes 1.3 million Soviet Jewish civilians who are also counted among the six million Jews.*





Image credit: NPR





*Image credit: New York Times*



# Uprooted

*“Between them Stalin and Hitler uprooted, transplanted, expelled, deported and dispersed some 30 million people in the years 1939–43.”*

— Tony Judt, *Postwar*, ch. 1

At the end of the war about 8 million displaced people were in Germany alone. Most went home within months: repatriations ran at 33,000 a day.

About 1.2 million could not or would not go back. Their camps operated into the 1950s.

Roughly 12 million Germans were expelled from Eastern Europe by 1950. Potsdam had called for transfers “in an orderly and humane manner.”



# Questions Facing Europe

- What to do about Germany
  - Partition, or reintegration?
- What to do about refugees and camp survivors?
- How to handle the legacy of fascism and the threat of communism?
- Prewar liberalism was discredited. What replaces it?
- And the colonies: can an anti-fascist, democratic, Europe stay imperial?



# One settlement, in three parts

## SECURITY

### **Tie Germany in, keep America in**

- Occupation gives way to integration
- NATO brings an American guarantee, 1949
- Coal and steel pooled, 1951

## ECONOMICS

### **Open markets, but with safety nets**

- Trade liberalized between European states
- Full employment becomes a government promise
- Welfare states built on market economy rather than in opposition to it

## POLITICS

### **Limit class conflict**

- Workers moderate their wage demands
- Employers accept unions and taxes
- Government guarantees demand and jobs

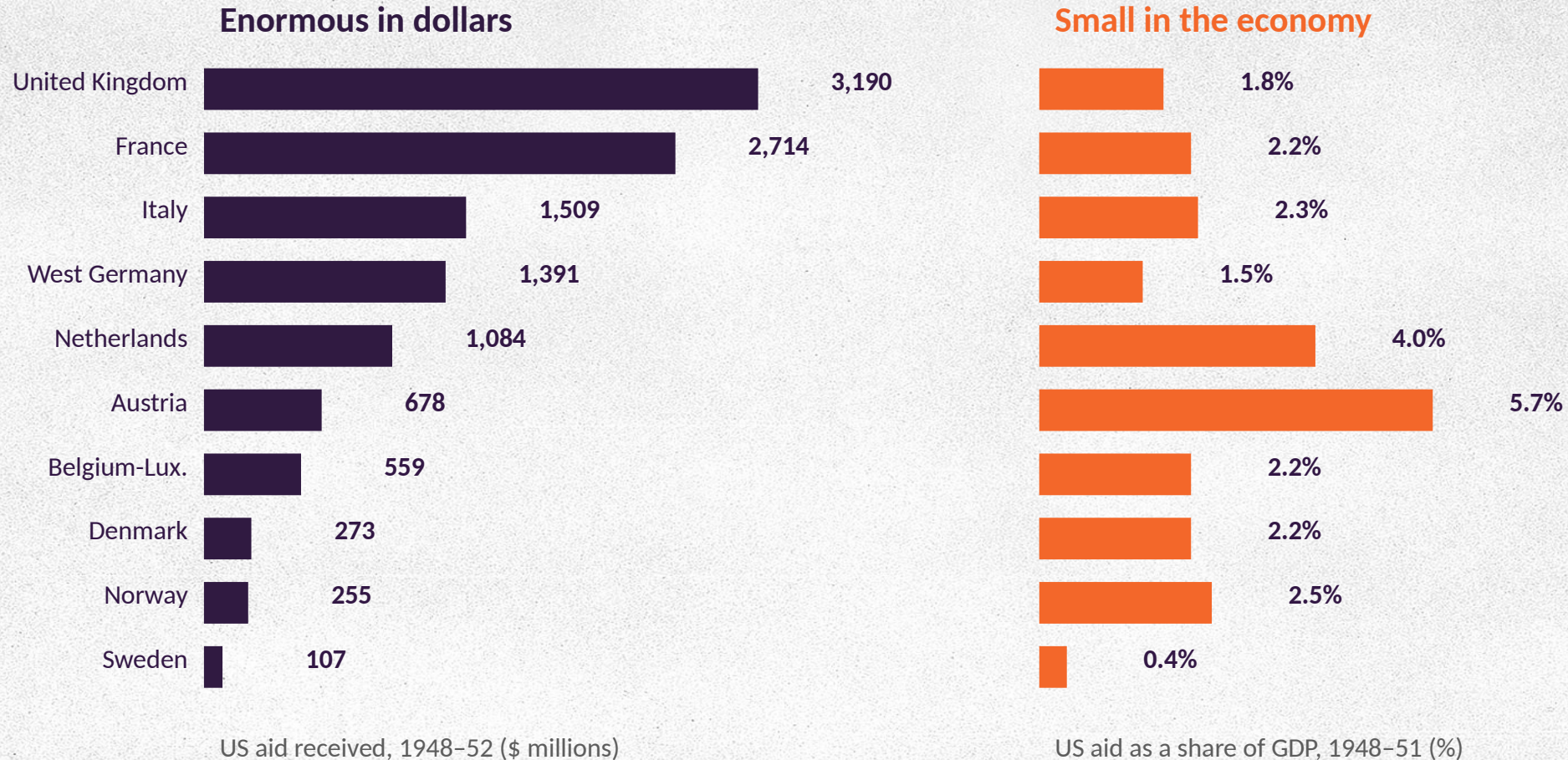


# The Crisis of 1947

- The winter of 1946–47 froze coal in the railway wagons
- British industry lost power; benefit claims spiked
- Europe could not earn the dollars to buy American goods
- Marshall made the offer at Harvard in June 1947
- Sterling turned convertible in July and collapsed in 37 days



# The Marshall Plan, in two views



Countries ordered by dollars received. Britain took the largest share of the money and among the smallest relative to its economy.  
Left: CRS R45079, 1948-52. Right: Crafts (2011), 1948-51 — different spans, different sources.



# What the Aid Bought

- Aid was under 3% of recipients' combined national income
- And less than a fifth of their gross investment
- De Long and Eichengreen: too small to explain the recovery by itself
- What it bought was policy — open markets, stable prices, balanced budgets
- And room to settle the fight over who got what

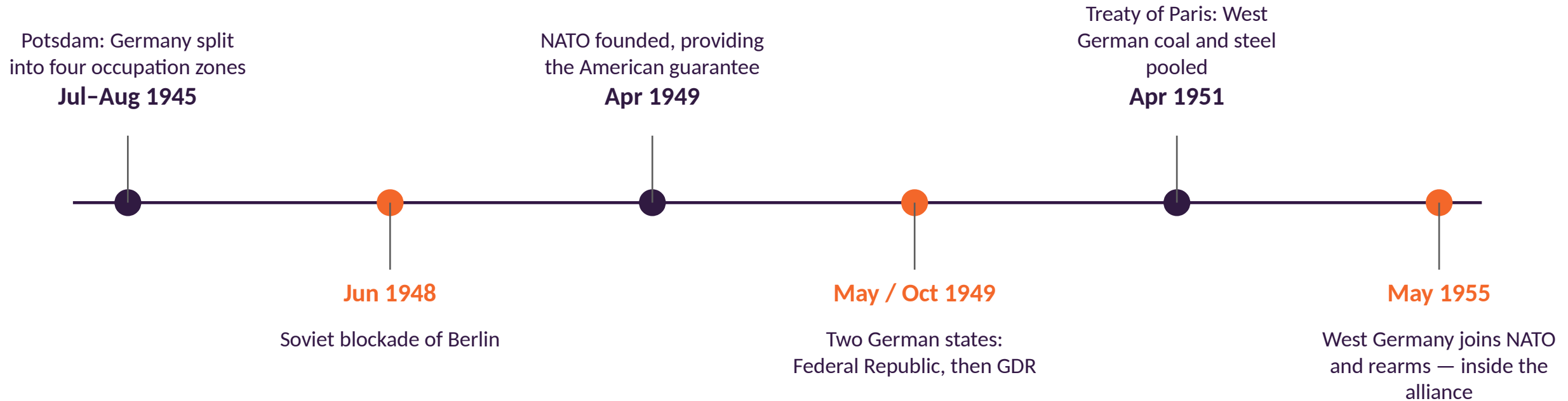


# The Marshall Plan Divided Europe

- The offer was open to all of Europe — the Soviet Union included
- Bohlen, State Department: “we gambled that the Soviets would not” join
- Molotov walked out; Stalin forced Czechoslovakia and Poland to withdraw
- The Cominform followed in September 1947, the Prague coup in February 1948
- Metz: the Plan hardened a division that lasted nearly fifty years



# What happened to Germany, 1945–1955





## Robert Schuman, 9 May 1950

*"World peace cannot be safeguarded without the making of creative efforts proportionate to the dangers which threaten it."*

*"Europe will not be made all at once, or according to a single plan. It will be built through concrete achievements which first create a de facto solidarity."*

*"The solidarity in production thus established will make it plain that any war between France and Germany becomes not merely unthinkable, but materially impossible."*



# Why Coal and Steel?

- They were the both materials of war, and the drivers of the peacetime economy
  - They sat in the contested borderland: the Ruhr and the Saar
- Pooling replaced Allied occupation with joint management
  - Narrow enough to negotiate, big enough to matter
- Schuman: “one limited but decisive point”

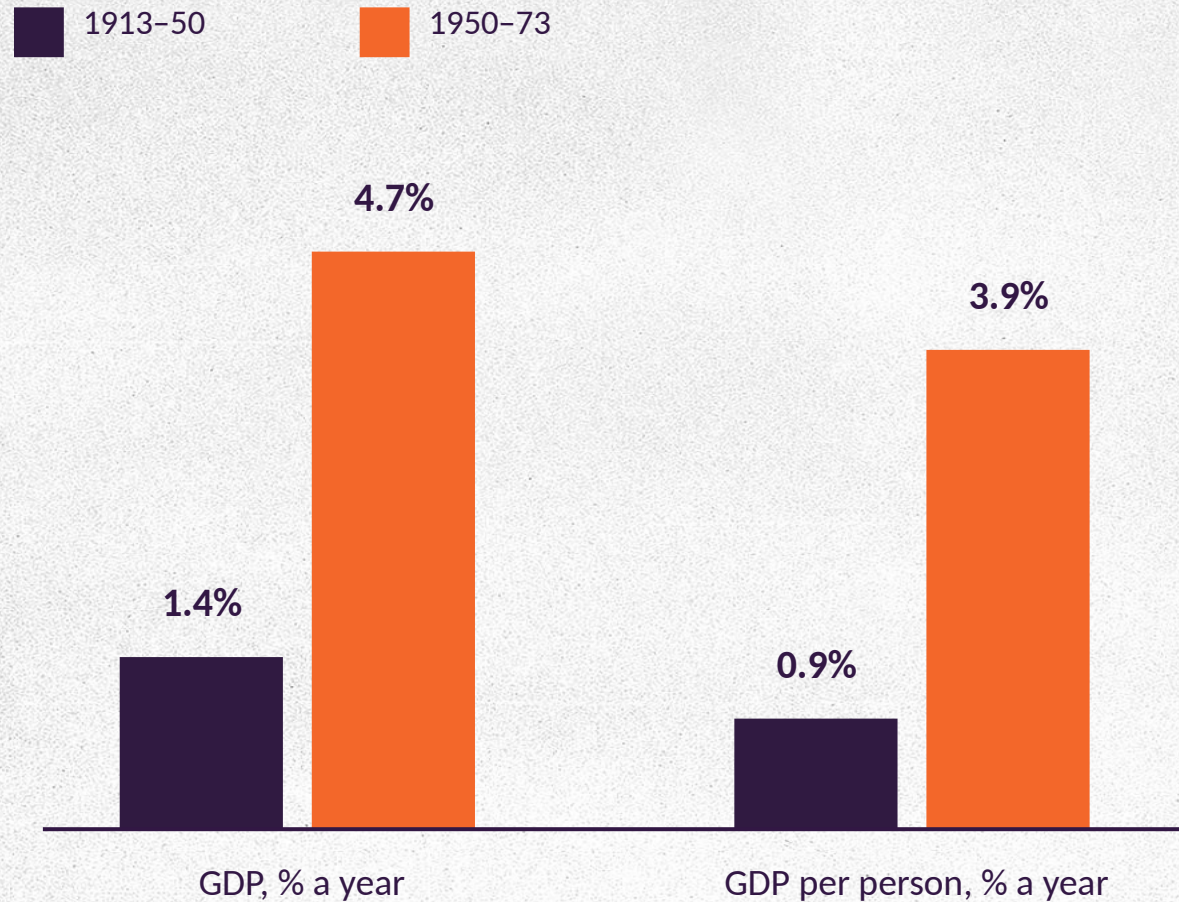


# The Coal and Steel Community

- Treaty of Paris signed 18 April 1951, in force 23 July 1952
- Six members: France, West Germany, Italy, Belgium, Netherlands, Luxembourg
  - Britain was invited to the negotiations and declined
- A High Authority with power over the member governments: the first European institution above the nation-state
- Written to last fifty years. It expired in 2002



# Growth before and after 1950



## ALONGSIDE THE GROWTH

Unemployment in the 1960s ran a little over 2%

At 3.9% a year, incomes double roughly every 18 years

A growing middle class took the heat out of the class conflict

Twelve Western European economies, average annual growth. Maddison (1995), via Eichengreen & Vázquez, Table 1.  
Unemployment: European Commission (1998) figures, via Bermeo (ed.), *Unemployment in the New Europe*.



# Why?

- Catch-up growth: Europe was rebuilding from a low base
- Abundant labor: the baby boom, and migration
- Government investment, driven partly by fear of communism
- Trade liberalization and stable exchange rates
- And the Marshall Plan, mostly through the policies it bought









Image credit: Der Spiegel



# Who actually built Europe?

## THE FOUNDING FATHERS

### Visionaries transcended the nation-state

- Monnet, Schuman, Adenauer, De Gasperi
- Supranational institutions with their own logic
- Spillover carries integration onward

## Self Interested Nation States (Milward's argument)

### Governments rescued themselves

- Every step a national calculation, ultimate power retained by nation-state
- Federalists had almost no influence at Paris
- Integration was the price of keeping national promises

*"To supersede the nation-state would be to destroy the Community." — Milward*



# Discussion

- Were the origins of this order idealistic: peace, reconciliation, “never again” or self-interested
  - (why) Does it matter?
- Which parts of the 1945 bargain are still standing in 2026, and which are being renegotiated?